More thoughtful practice, more practical thought: Practitioners, theoreticians, and barrier-crossing hybrids

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For millennia, thinkers have debated the relationship between theory and practice—between knowing by thinking (*theoria*) and knowing by doing (*phronesis*). Yet the gap between theoreticians and practitioners persists across modern contexts, generating misunderstandings and slowing the translation of insight into action. This study explores how these orientations manifest in the fields of social science and social change, and whether a third form—the 'hybrid', who bridges thinking and doing—can reconcile them. Drawing on interviews with 20 theoreticians, practitioners, and hybrids, we applied a mixed-methods design combining human-led thematic analysis with an AI-assisted quantitative LLM analysis. Analysis identified four recurring patterns shaping relations between theory and practice: (1) hybrids as translators between theory and practice; (2) institutional frictions and navigation; (3) temporal asymmetries between research and practice; and (4) boundary spanning as a mode of impact. Participants described shared core values but divergent tempos, aims, and institutional incentives, with hybrids acting as boundary-spanners who translated between abstract knowledge and lived experience. AI-based scaling analyses revealed systematic linguistic polarization around a 'theory-authority' versus 'practice-pluralist' axis, yet convergence toward the latter, indicating widespread endorsement of situated, collaborative knowledge creation. We argue that the theory–practice divide is sustained less by active opposition than by structural inertia. Enlisting Aristotelian thinking as a model of practical wisdom provides a conceptual bridge: more thoughtful practice, and more practical thought.

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Questions about how human beings know the world are as old as philosophy itself. The ancient Greeks articulated some of the earliest distinctions between theoretical and practical ways of knowing, distinctions that continue to shape modern debates (Westberg, 1994). These categories have influenced Western thought for over two millennia (Nussbaum, 2001; Nightingale, 2004), yet the tensions between them are far from resolved. The 'theory-practice divide' has been studied in fields as diverse as education (Bailey & Gautam, 2015), international development (Bullivant, 2022), and organizational identity (Lam, 2020), yet much of this work either emphasises one side of the divide or assumes the categories of knowledge are fixed. We turn to these challenges in the fields of social knowledge and change and examine a third type of actor that appears to move between these domains: the 'hybrid'. Hybrids operate across both theoretical and practical settings, and may therefore offer insight into how the boundary between theory and practice is experienced, maintained, and occasionally bridged.

The present research is inspired by a classic conception from the history of philosophy that illuminates the task of building social knowledge and strengthening practice. In the *Nicomachean Ethics* (Bartlett & Collins, 2011), Aristotle identifies three forms of knowing—the thinker's (*theoria*), the actor's (*phronesis*), and the builder's (*poesis*). *Theoria* is about knowing, not doing. *Phronesis* is the kind of knowing based in experience that makes it possible to act—to do—well. When solid theory-practice-theory (or 'praxis') links are made, when thinkers based in the academy and actors on the streets come into effective relation around shared goals, theory is energized and practice deepened (Wallerstein et al., 2020; Oetzel et al., 2022), addressing particularly pernicious issues like HIV prevention in the Global South (Pickles et al., 2013) or gun crime in the US (Butts et al., 2015).

The difference between practical and theoretical wisdom is, for instance, the difference between seasoned, effective community leaders who know nothing of the sociology of leadership and academics who know the theory but do not have the skills or experience to be effective community leaders. Relatedly, Schwartz & Sharpe (2011) argue that in organizational settings, effective action depends critically on contextual understanding and experience. Successful administrators, coaches, teachers, parents, politicians, supervisors, civil society leaders, police officers, volunteers and other practical actors may refine and deepen their knowledge through formal education, but what makes them good at practical tasks largely depends on what they have learned from life experience (Schweigert, 2007). Without the manifold social knowledge and skills of these Aristotelian leaders

(Nussbaum, 1990), society as we know it would fragment. Neither theoreticians nor practitioners alone can sustain or transform the web of social relations.

Single-minded fidelity to one viewpoint feeds an unwillingness to contaminate oneself by involvement in the inevitable pluralistic messiness of life (Mikowski, 2024). Concern only for effective action encourages an unprincipled pragmatism; in focusing too narrowly on the effectiveness of what we will *do*, we lose the perspective and motivational grounding of *why* we do it. Similarly, being overly focused on the *why* leaves us mistakenly thinking that the *how* will take care of itself. We also examine a third type of actor, the 'hybrid', who works across both theoretical and practical domains. In other fields, this role has been described as 'scholar-practitioner leadership' within education (Bailey, 2014; Bailey & Gautam, 2015) or management (Carton & Ungureanu, 2017), and 'community leaders' in civil society (Chambers, 2018; Khalifa, 2012).

Aristotle's conception of practical wisdom has been centrally embedded in Western vocabularies and dispositions for more than twenty centuries (Lord, 2013; Lobkowicz, 1967). It is our hope and expectation that this classic conception will offer readers a tool for shared critical reflection on the practical problem of energizing the link between those who primarily act, and those who primarily think in a variety of settings. Each brings something irreplaceable to the tasks of social action and, we believe, to their interlocutors' wisdom and effectiveness. Our aim is to better understand the conditions under which theory and practice diverge or converge, and the mediating role hybrids may play.

The present study

This research sought to address two key questions. First, what are the similarities and differences in participants' accounts of their perspectives, aspirations and actions in relation to theory and practice? Second, what structural, institutional, and epistemic factors contribute to these similarities and differences? In doing so, we treat the theory–practice divide not simply as a problem to be solved but as a social arrangement that may persist for structural, institutional, or epistemic reasons. To explore this, we conducted interviews with twenty subjects. The actors you will meet are either social scientists, social interventionists, or those whose work traverses both spheres. For the purposes of this study, theoreticians conduct research and build theories. Their base is the university, and their passion is to know the world of society and culture, including its historical and evolutionary background. In this article, the term *theoretician* is used in the Aristotelian sense associated with *theoria* (Bartlett & Collins, 2011), referring to an orientation toward conceptual inquiry and the pursuit of knowledge rather than implying that individuals necessarily generate novel formal theories. In contrast, practitioners work to ameliorate social conditions like chronic poverty, public corruption, and

inter-group divisions. Their base is the streets, and their driving intention is to change things there for the better. Hybrids engage simultaneously in both worlds, commuting back and forth between the university and the streets. Their animating motivation is igniting a synergy between knowing and changing how things are, between the world as is and the world as it could be. All three seek a better world.

Our mixed-methods design employed a human-led thematic analysis and AI-led language processing to look for statistical linkages among and between groups (theoreticians, practitioners, and hybrids). We incorporated a computational language-analysis component using Large Language Models (LLMs) to complement the human-led thematic analysis and examine patterns in how participants articulate positions within the theory–practice divide. This second component does not replace qualitative analysis but complements it by transforming interview transcripts into structured analytical representations and mapping patterns of alignment and divergence in how participants frame theory, practice, and collaboration. By triangulating evidence across methods, we enact the values of collaboration across disciplinary borders, bringing together a team from psychology, anthropology, and computer science.

Methods

Procedure and participants

Twenty-one social scientists and social change actors from the USA and UK were invited to participate in an interview about their experiences of academia and practice, of which 20 consented to interview. Interviews were semi-structured with 10 key questions included in each interview concerning interviewees experiences and perspectives on theory and practice (see Appendix 1 for the questions). The lead researchers identified participants as 'theoreticians' (n = 5), 'practitioners' (n = 8), or a combination of both termed 'hybrids' (n = 7) based on their career trajectories and experiences obtained through personal knowledge and the interviewees' public websites. Interviews were conducted by an experienced female research assistant between July 2024 and February 2025. Participants provided informed consent prior to answering questions, which were recorded and later anonymized and transcribed. Interviews typically lasted an average of 50 minutes. All names have been changed to protect anonymity.

Analysis

Study 1: Human-led qualitative analysis

Using the Aristotelian framing, our analysis was theoretically informed rather than fully inductive, using the conceptual distinction between theoretical and practical knowledge as a sensitising

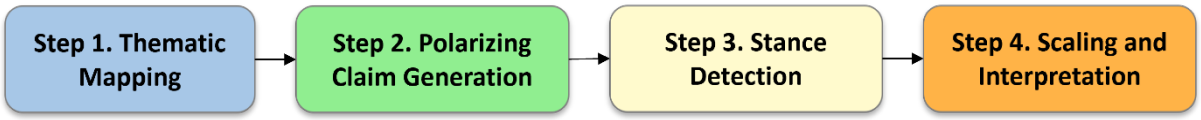
deductive framework while remaining open to additional insights emerging from the data. An adapted version of Nowell et al.'s (2017) approach to thematic analysis was used and facilitated by NVivo software. We began by familiarizing ourselves with the entire dataset. The lead researchers read all transcripts, noting initial reflections and developing an agreed list of areas of analytic interest based on our research aims. Two coders then used these areas of interest to guide initial coding, working systematically through each transcript to identify relevant sections of text. Labels were attached to these extracts to index them under relevant themes or issues, ensuring codes were clear, non-overlapping, and theoretically aligned. At the same time, coders remained open to unexpected insights, adding additional codes where participants raised ideas outside the initial framework.

Coding was facilitated through NVivo, and memos were used to capture impressions and emerging patterns. Following independent coding of an initial transcript, the coders met to compare codes, refine definitions, and achieve consensus. This iterative process was repeated across the dataset, producing a shared coding framework. All relevant coded extracts were then collated and grouped into themes and subthemes that captured both researchers' a priori interests and any emergent findings. The themes were then reviewed, refined, named, and organized into a logical structure by the lead researchers, ensuring coherence and conceptual clarity. Finally, the table of themes and subthemes was reduced when writing up and reviewing the literature to reduce content and subthemes that overlapped to too great a degree. Following peer review, theme names were further strengthened.

Study 2: AI-led quantitative analyses

Recent advances show that Large Language Models (LLMs) can augment social science research by coding qualitative data and scaling interpretive tasks (Rosenbusch et al., 2023; Bail, 2024). Building on this trend, we developed a four-step LLM-based pipeline (Fig.1) that combines theme, sub-theme, and polarizing claim generation with the ANCO-Hits algorithm (Gokalp et al., 2013). This approach positions participants and claims along a one-dimensional, continuous, and interpretable scale. The four steps are outlined in detail in Figure 1. This approach was taken to enhance scalability, reduce bias, and create reproducible accounts of stance dynamics (Çetinkaya et al., 2024; Çetinkaya et al., 2025).

Figure 1. *Quantitative LLM-based processing pipeline*



Thematic Mapping (Step 1). The LLM processed 20 interview transcripts, provided in a structured format containing questions, responses, and comments from practitioners, theoreticians, and hybrids.

It identified recurring themes—defined as ideas present across multiple participants, explicitly or implicitly—and organized them into themes and sub-themes with paraphrased explanations. This stage produced an AI-generated thematic map, later compared with the human-coded deductive analysis to assess alignment, overlap, and divergence. Prompt P1 in Appendix 2 guided this task.

Polarizing Claim Generation (Step 2). We sought to extract polarizing claims directly from interviewees' statements. Owing to the collaborative framing of interview questions, however, few strongly oppositional claims emerged. To capture implicit polarization, the LLM was prompted to generate polarizing claims grounded in Step 1 themes, phrased as concise, oppositional pairs reflecting latent tensions between theoreticians and practitioners. Iterative generation continued until thematic saturation, producing a final set of 64 AI-generated polarizing claim pairs. Prompt P2 in Appendix 2 guided this task.

Stance Detection (Step 3). Each interview transcript was paired with each AI-generated claim. The LLM was tasked with inferring whether the participant likely supported, opposed, or expressed no clear position on a given claim, even when the issue was not explicitly addressed. To ensure depth, the model was instructed to provide evidence-based justifications explicitly referencing participants' worldviews, values, traits, and tone. Prompt P3 in Appendix 2 guided this task, producing a participant-by-claim stance matrix for consistency and downstream analysis.

Scaling and Interpretation (Step 4). The participant-by-claim stance matrix was modelled as a signed bipartite graph, with participants and claims forming two node sets connected by positive (support) or negative (oppose) edges. The ANCO-HITS algorithm (Gokalp et al., 2013) partitioned both participants and claims into camps and placed them along a continuous scale from −1 to 1. This scaling positioned participants closer to the claims they supported and farther from those they opposed. ANCO-HITS effectively maps the landscape of disagreement, revealing where ideas attract or repel, and translates polarization into discernible patterns. To interpret these results, the LLM was provided with claim scores, participant scores, participant types, and stance data. This interpretive step was guided by Prompt P4 in Appendix 2.

Results

Study 1: Human-led qualitative results

To understand how theoreticians, practitioners, and hybrids work, we employed a deductive approach to thematic analysis, through which four analytic dimensions emerged with associated recurring patterns identified, see Table 1. These patterns are presented below as organising themes that structure the diversity of interview accounts. However, the analytic emphasis lies in participants' self-descriptions and interpretations of their roles—for example, how hybrids position themselves as

translators between communities, or describe moments of recognition, alienation, or institutional constraint—rather than in the thematic labels themselves. The themes therefore function as a way of organising these interpretive insights rather than as standalone findings, consistent with reflexive thematic analysis approaches in qualitative psychology (Braun & Clarke, 2006; Braun & Clarke, 2019). The findings reported below reflect patterns in how participants described their experiences and perceptions rather than objective differences between groups.

Table 1.

Themes and subthemes

Theme	Subthemes
Theme 1: Divergent orientations to knowledge and practice	1.1. Shared values but divergent priorities 1.2. Contrasting epistemic orientations
Theme 2: Structural Barriers to Integration	2.1. Divergent motivations and work contexts 2.2. Institutional gatekeeping and academic incentives 2.3. Communication and accessibility barriers 2.4. Resource and ecological constraints on collaboration
Theme 3. The paradox of cross-boundary collaboration	3.2 Mutual learning and enrichment 3.2. Alienation and power asymmetries 3.3. Practical constraints and scepticism about co-engagement
Theme 4: From individual 'hybrids' to institutional co-production	4.1. Shared commitment for knowledge creation 4.2. Fostering spaces for dialogue and engagement

Theme 1. Divergent orientations to knowledge and practice

This theme illustrates how participants construed the values and epistemic orientations of practitioner, theoretician, and hybrid roles. Participants articulated distinct value profiles and epistemic stances across groups. Although interviewees shared common interpersonal attributes, they described divergent stances toward action versus knowledge production and toward situated versus abstract

ways of knowing. Hybrids portrayed themselves as translators who integrated practice-grounded insight with theoretical inquiry.

1.1. Shared values but divergent priorities

Interviewees identified distinct sets of core values attributed to practitioners, theoreticians, and hybrids. While there was some common ground — with participants across groups frequently highlighting respect, responsibility, and kindness as important interpersonal qualities — key differences emerged in how participants approached knowledge and practice. Several participants described practitioners as action-oriented and grounded in lived realities, demonstrating a high tolerance for uncertainty and challenging situations. As one participant noted:

> *"A practitioner works in the world of action, primarily."* (P17, Hybrid)

Theoreticians were framed and framed themselves as primarily concerned with knowledge creation, conceptual clarity, and intellectual rigor, often operating at a level of abstraction removed from immediate practice. As P11 explained:

> *"Theoreticians...They're thinking, they're trying to keep the bigger thing moving, but they're not action oriented. Practitioners have to be action oriented."* (P11, Hybrid)

This drive for knowledge, while celebrated, was also described as a source of tension — both within academic spaces and when collaborating with practitioners. Some practitioners expressed uncertainty about the values underpinning theoretical work. One practitioner also commented that they had *"no idea"* what values theoreticians held (P1, Practitioner), speaking to the gulf between value stances. Hybrids — participants who straddled both worlds — were uniquely positioned, combining community wisdom, practical experience, and an enduring pursuit of knowledge. They were described as recognizing and valuing plural ways of knowing, functioning as boundary-spanners who reconcile inquiry with action:

> *"We wanted to be a practitioner that could bring in and use theory to improve practices. And it required knowledge of both. To do that, you had to have theoretical understanding, and you had to have practical knowledge to go in and perform that function."* (P12, Hybrid)

Participants across groups frequently described shared interpersonal values such as openness, awareness, listening and respect, but we also observed a fundamental divergence in orientation: practitioners prioritize action, theoreticians emphasize knowledge generation, and hybrids attempt to synthesize both, often mediating between conflicting epistemologies.

1.2. Contrasting epistemic orientations

Participants frequently described practitioners and theoreticians as drawing on different forms of knowledge. For instance, practitioners' knowledge was commonly depicted as situated and participatory:

> *"There's a profound difference… it's the difference between doing something where you're part of the experience yourself and your participation has an impact on the outcome, versus being a neutral observer."* (P16, Practitioner)

> *"The practitioner is, I think, in general, much more interested in what are the dynamics… what is the difference between the expected scenario and the experienced scenario."* (P1, Practitioner)

Hybrids appeared to be translators who "spoke both languages," integrating divergent ways of knowing and moving fluidly across settings. Some hybrids resisted rigid dichotomies entirely, depicting research–practice as an iterative cycle and emphasizing the epistemic vantage of liminal "in-between" spaces:

> *"So for me, the practice is the piece for empowering, how to use research and knowledge for power. So for me, research and practice is like a circle, you know?... Research should be constantly thinking about these ideas, putting them into practice and seeing how we, you know, continually refine the theoretical knowledge."* (P6, Hybrid)

> *I have a very strong belief in, you know, liminality, like liminal spaces where, you know, you're in between, you know, two things because I think that that gives you a vantage point… but the one who has an eye to the door, who knows what's happening on the border, like on the liminality, like the liminal zones that do not belong to either or."* (P5, Hybrid)

Practitioners were often cast as decision-makers under uncertainty, theoreticians as stewards of conceptual clarity and disciplined inquiry, and hybrids as boundary-spanners who translate across these orientations. Hybrids appeared to show that integration is possible when individuals are intentionally willing to cultivate boundary-spanning roles and recognize the value of diverse epistemic perspectives. Taken together, these findings suggest that the differences are not merely stylistic but epistemic and valuational in nature — shaping how problems are framed, which evidence counts, and what "good work" looks like — and they help situate the persistent divide between theoreticians and practitioners.

Theme 2: Structural Barriers to Integration

Practice and Theory

This theme explores how differing aims and approaches, institutional gatekeeping, communication practices, and ecological and resource constraints sustain silos between theoreticians and practitioners. Participants acknowledged the interdependence of scholarship and practice and the value of cross-boundary work yet described purpose misalignment and structural frictions that make integration challenging, even when hybrids attempted to bridge both worlds.

2.1. Divergent motivations and work contexts

Practitioners and theoretician goals diverged sharply at times. Participants contrasted knowledge advancement as a theoretician's primary motivation with tangible impact and helping others as a practitioner's chief aims, further supporting Theme 1:

> *"I am indeed one of the ivory tower types in the sense that I do, I'm committed to thinking and doing this work largely for its own sake, rather than for its translatability into programs and practices in the outside world."* (P8, Theoretician)

Participants also noted how academic work becomes siloed by prioritizing publications and theoretical debates over practical engagement:

> *"The social scientists can go off and sit in their room and read books and write stuff… They don't fundamentally have to go beyond that, unless they choose to."* (P14, Hybrid)

By contrast, practitioners highlighted the relational nature of their work:

> *"These public living rooms we're producing… people don't have to relive their lived experience story all the time. They can just have company and connection… That's knitting together their confidence and their feeling of self-worth."* (P3, Practitioner)

This tension reflects deeper epistemic divides: the theoretical paradigm emphasizes conceptual precision, whereas the practitioner paradigm prioritizes human relationships and adaptability in complex, dynamic contexts.

2.2. Divergent Timelines and Tempo

Participants consistently described academics and practitioners as operating on incompatible timelines and at different tempos, with academic cycles lagging behind practice needs and creating friction when trying to translate theory into practice:

> *"For example, regulation of artificial intelligence… somebody produces a white paper, and then you have a debate and consultation. That takes a couple of years. By the time you come out at the end of it, it's four or five years on. If you think AI is in the same place in four or five*

> *weeks or months, never mind years, you don't really know what's going on… theory and practice have very different time zones."* (P14, Hybrid)

This "temporal divide" often meant that theoretical outputs arrived too late to inform pressing decisions, leaving practitioners to further rely on experience rather than evidence and fueling frustration with the academic system.2.2. Institutional gatekeeping and academic incentives

Some participants suggested that academic institutions actively preserve boundaries between scholars and practitioners, often reinforcing knowledge hierarchies that elevate scholarly status and distance practitioners:

> *"The academy has set itself up where scholars have distinguished themselves from average ordinary everyday practitioners… and I think that's what allows us to claim to be scholars… This was done by the scholars, right? In their own self-interest."* (P10, Theoretician)

This boundary-setting could foster epistemic elitism, in which academic frameworks are treated as superior and practitioner insights are sidelined. Some described a risk-averse culture in which academics hesitate to test ideas in practice for fear of exposure to real-world scrutiny:

> *"Some theoreticians don't really try to test their ideas. They don't want to do that because they fear that their ideas might be proved to not be very successful or not stand up to the test of practice."* (P14, Hybrid)

Additionally, several participants pointed to the prestige economy of academia, noting that incentive structures delimit what "counts" as legitimate scholarship:

> "*You have to publish or perish, and you have to publish in the journals. Nobody reads the damn thing. As far as a practitioner's point of view. I've hoped and I have pushed and I've asked universities that I've come in contact with one way or the other, particularly in the fields that are actually very much engaged in what's going on in the world, real-time policing. Give credit to young professors who are seeking tenure, not because they wrote a peer-reviewed journal article. But they wrote articles in the Police Chief magazine that reaches 100,000 people a month.*" (P11, Hybrid)

These accounts depict an academic system that maintains boundaries through prestige-driven reward structures, risk-averse norms, and assumptions that privilege specialist knowledge — patterns that elevate scholarly authority and overlook practitioner insight. Notably, participants did not report parallel gatekeeping from practitioners, suggesting that the asymmetry in status and access largely originates within academic institutional logics.

2.3. Communication and accessibility barriers

Many participants highlighted how academic work often fails to reach practitioners because it is inaccessible, overly technical, or poorly translated into practice, which can further reinforce epistemic elitism:

> *"I need material that is presented in a way that is easily accessible to me as a practitioner on the ground… There's a barrier in terms of academics not necessarily being prepared to make their work usable."* (P1, Practitioner)

> *"Most of it is couched in discipline-based jargon, and because it's only communicated amongst sociologists… folks on the ground don't have that base language, so it doesn't reach them."* (P13, Hybrid)

Others pointed to publication practices that further restrict reach:

> *"I've got this book based on my dissertation… The publisher priced it for libraries. The average nonprofit person who wants to use it can't afford it… I haven't done anything with it because it's inaccessible."* (P13, Hybrid)

Participants' accounts suggest that knowledge circulation mechanisms — academic publishing, pricing models, and disciplinary silos — may unintentionally exclude the very audiences who can enact theory: practitioners.

2.4. Resource and ecological constraints on collaboration

Several participants described structural and funding barriers that limit opportunities for interaction and collaboration:

> *"A principal barrier to that kind of interaction is simply that we don't have occasion to chat with each other. We don't cross paths."* (P8, Theoretician)

Institutional funding priorities also reinforced divides:

> *"The institution lives on status. Status is fuelled by money… Bringing money into the institution is really important to keep research going. So the practitioner's value is tied to how much revenue they generate, not necessarily to the insights they offer."* (P17, Hybrid)

This resource-driven dynamic reinforced unequal power relations by privileging academically recognized outputs over practical expertise. Participants frequently attributed disconnections between theoreticians and practitioners to divergent goals and approaches, compounded by academic gatekeeping, communication practices, and structural and funding constraints as evidenced above. The resultant silos appear to slow knowledge translation and limit the practical impact of research.

Theme 3: The paradox of cross-boundary collaboration

Collaboration among practitioners, theoreticians, and hybrids was often portrayed by participants as both promising and challenging. Although participants reported benefits such as gaining new perspectives, enhancing their skills, and building meaningful relationships, they also highlighted recurring tensions around communication, power, and recognition.

3.1. Mutual learning and enrichment

For many practitioners, collaboration facilitated mutual learning and reciprocity, often yielding deeper insights than working in isolation. Several described how working across epistemic boundaries exposed them to different schools of thought and enriched their own practice:

> *"The cultural context for camaraderie was highlighted by the academics. They said, "I think you'll have a challenge here… [academics] throws light on our work by telling us about other people who've done it before."* (P3, Practitioner)

Others appreciated being able to connect individual experiences to broader evidence bases, particularly when implementing small-scale interventions:

> *"I am working with people sort of one-on-one, so my sample size is smaller, so I appreciate being able to sort of hear about how these interventions do seem to be working in a larger sample size."* (P19, Practitioner)

The process was even described as personally rewarding and even essential to professional fulfilment:

> *"I don't know possibly how I could sit here and look back on a rich and rewarding life professionally and spiritually and practically if I weren't consistently eager to be engaged with theoretical terms of teachers and writers."* (P9, Practitioner)

Engaging across boundaries also provided exposure to alternative perspectives, often reframing long-standing assumptions and reconfiguring design choices:

> *"I can't imagine that I ever would have been able to do what I was asked to do and possibly as successfully as I did it if I were not consistently involved with theoretical thought and action."* (P9, Practitioner)

> *"The challenge we got from the academic round table about cultural context has illuminated our practice and made us think much more about literally everything right down to the materials we use and how we run events."* (P3, Practitioner)

This shift toward integrative perspectives was frequently supported by hybrids, who helped translate across domains and invited others to move beyond rigid intellectual silos.

3.2. Alienation and power asymmetries

Despite these gains, many participants expressed frustration at persistent communication breakdowns and power imbalances. A recurrent theme was that practitioners often felt unheard, undervalued, or excluded from decision-making processes when working with academics. As one participant described:

> *"The reality is that we've dug this enormously deep trench, and we can't talk to each other."* (P9, Practitioner)

Others echoed this view, noting that engagement often fell short of genuine collaboration. Collaborations were at times dominated by theoreticians, leaving practitioners with narrow influence. Many observed that conversations with academics tended to be descriptive rather than co-creative, curtailing practitioners' contributions to shaping theory. Some described practitioners being sometimes treated primarily as sources of data rather than equal partners:

> *"These people aren't going to listen, they don't actually want to hear from the practitioner, they want to tell the practitioner why it was wrong."* (P1, Practitioner)

> *"I work with the people who make the decisions about a lot of the things I used to do… And I realized now that my frustration at the time was well placed. If people don't really know what they're talking about… they haven't got the lived experience of doing the work. And yet, they are in a position that is very powerful in determining how that work is done."* (P16, Practitioner)

> *"All the interaction that takes place is only as a source of information, only as a data point."* (P4, Theoretician)

> *"They never really sat down with me… to dialogue about theory and what the implications of what they're trying to learn… I never got a sense of what they were dealing with in terms of what they're going to do with that."* (P13, Hybrid)

This lack of reciprocity was identified as a major barrier:

> *"It has to be a two-way street. And when it's not, it doesn't work. It doesn't. I know so many practitioners that just turn it off. They don't have time for it."* (P7, Practitioner)

This perception of imbalanced relationships underscores structural issues around priorities, incentives, and ownership in knowledge production.

3.3. Practical constraints and scepticism about co-engagement

Even when relationships were positive, participants acknowledged that time constraints and institutional demands often limited opportunities for deeper engagement. Practitioners, in particular, were challenged by balancing everyday demands with additional collaborative work:

> *"We're just trying to get the job done each day and not thinking about new ways of doing that work."* (P18, Practitioner)

> *"From my experience with practitioners, they don't have time to bother with that."* (P13, Hybrid)

Finally, not all participants agreed that collaboration was necessary or productive. One expressed scepticism about the practical utility of frequent cross-boundary engagement:

> *"So I think there can be benefit from interacting and talking about, you know, subjective perceptions and differences in interpretation. But I don't think that in most cases, it is making a huge contribution to like theoretical refinement of models because they don't share the same assumptions about how you would construct a meaningful model about like virtual psychology."* (P2, Theoretician)

A dual function of barrier-crossing collaboration emerged: on one hand, participants described transformative learning, mutual enrichment, and personal fulfilment; on the other, they revealed entrenched communication barriers, status hierarchies, and participation constraints. Although optimism about collaborative potential was widespread, many argued that success depends on reciprocity and sustained time investment — factors that are often in short supply, especially when communication is weak and paradigms diverge.

Theme 4: From individual 'hybrids' to institutional co-production

The final theme captures participants' aspirations for deeper, reciprocal interactions among theoreticians, practitioners, and barrier crossing leaders that advance mutual understanding, improve practice, and make research more relevant to real-world challenges. Although many expressed

enthusiasm for closer integration, they also emphasized that meaningful collaboration requires intentional effort and sustained commitment. They also underscored the need for structural and cultural changes to support mutual knowledge creation, practical impact, and sustainable co-production.

4.1. Shared commitment for knowledge creation

Participants consistently argued that theoreticians and practitioners should both contribute to knowledge production, rather than treating academics as the sole gatekeepers. In this context, 'shared knowledge creation' refers to collaborative processes in which practitioners contribute experiential insight while academics contribute conceptual and analytical frameworks, with both shaping research questions, interpretation, and application.

> *"Practitioners should be contributing to that body of knowledge as well. It's not just about academics doing new work in the area."* (P1, Practitioner)

> *"I don't sort of devalue one or value one more than the other. I think they're very deeply connected… Theory always informs your action, and your experience informs your theoretical framework. The two are quite complementary."* (P5, Hybrid)

Another recurring idea was the need for earlier involvement — bringing theoreticians and practitioners together from the outset of a project to co-design goals and methods:

> *"I personally think that practitioners like me need to have the academics on board from day one… So that they're part of the team… And similarly, I think academics could find ways of being a little bit more action-orientated in their learning, visiting projects, coming to see us, sitting down around the table."* (P3, Practitioner)

Practitioners also pointed to the potential benefits of engaging with theoreticians. Some emphasized scholars' ability to render complex findings usable for frontline work, while others stressed the value of accessible frameworks, including guidebooks and toolkits. For instance, the "theory of change" was seen as particularly useful for structuring decision-making and improving interventions:

> *"I think a theorist is someone who's really bright… and then they may come up with some new ideas… and make it so that it's available to those of us who are on the frontline. And then we can take that and translate that into actual work that we're doing."* (P18, Practitioner)

> *"As practitioners, we're looking for guidebooks, toolkits… the theory of change is really important. We're producing theories of change in our heads all the time… If you've got a*

> *guidebook or a companion that demystifies the academic work, that really, really helps."* (P1, Practitioner)

Several participants suggested that a shift toward storytelling — rather than focusing exclusively on publishing "facts" — could help make research more accessible, relatable, and actionable for communities:

> *"Facts on their own don't change things; stories make sense of them."* (P9, Practitioner)

Rather than rejecting theory, practitioners sought accessible tools that help them apply evidence to real-world problems. This priority reflects a desire for bidirectional flows of knowledge, where practice challenges theory and theory informs practice.

4.2. Fostering spaces for dialogue and engagement

Participants highlighted that building stronger, sustained partnerships is key to overcoming mistrust and enabling co-created solutions to complex problems. They offered a range of suggestions for how to foster more meaningful, reciprocal collaborations, including the need for creating shared spaces for constructive engagement where practitioners and theoreticians can discuss, debate, and learn from each other:

> *"…we need spaces where scholars and practitioners can work together on shared problems, and actually co-author solutions that work on the ground."* (P6, Hybrid)

> *"We need spaces where we can actually meet each other as equals — where the roles aren't so rigid. If we're going to build anything lasting, there has to be time carved out for genuine dialogue."* (P7, Practitioner)

However, participants stressed that engagement must be intentional rather than *ad hoc* encounters, which requires time and institutional support to sustain:

> *"I think the way to deal with that is through the ability to provide a dialogue space between the two extremes to cause an understanding of the importance of each extreme. And I think it takes studies like this to come to the realization that there's this gulf between the two that needs to be put together in ways that can be greatly helpful to society."* (P15, Practitioner)

Finally, some proposed cross-exposure and training to cultivate empathy and shared understanding across domains. For instance, theoreticians could spend time observing practice in context, while practitioners could gain access to workshops on research design and interpretation:

> *"I think there's still a lot of prejudice on both sides, and we don't always understand each other's pressures. More training and shared experiences would help — not to make us the same, but so we can work better together."* (P15, Practitioner)

Participants envision dialogue not as a courtesy but as deliberate practice: intentionally designed, shared spaces where practitioners and theoreticians meet as equals to listen, debate, and co-author solutions that work on the ground. They emphasized that time, institutional backing, and cross-exposure and training experiences are necessary for durable partnerships capable of delivering practical impact.

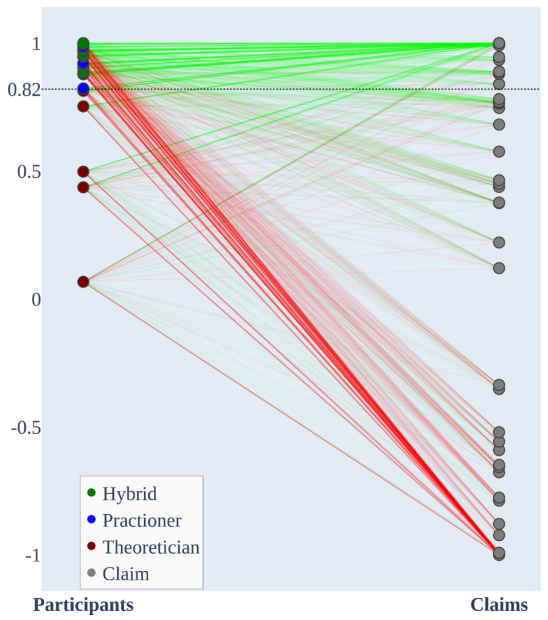
This final theme indicates that most participants aspire to dismantle rigid boundaries between theory and practice, replacing hierarchical relationships with mutual knowledge creation and structured co-production. The focus on dialogue and accessible frameworks supported by institutional and structural support underscores a paradigm where the integration of theory and praxis becomes the norm through collaboration, rather than being reliant on the effort of individual hybrids to bridge the divide.

Study 2: Quantitative results

The LLM identified 7 themes and 23 sub-themes shown in Table 1 in Appendix 3, closely paralleling the human-coded categories such as values, skills, theory–practice engagement, and sources of division, with differences limited to phrasing. The key themes are explored in depth with supporting quotes in the Qualitative Results. Here we focus on the structural differences between practitioners, theoreticians, and hybrids. From the LLM-identified themes, 32 oppositional claim pairs were generated and scaled with ANCO-HITS, revealing structured alignments across the theory–practice divide (Figure 2a). From the 64 polarizing claims, there was a strikingly bimodal distribution, with many claims concentrated near the poles and very few near the midpoint.

Claims at the negative extreme articulate a 'theory-first' position (e.g., the necessity of scholarly authority, the primacy of abstraction and universality, and the idea that practitioners gain credibility only when aligned to theoretical standards). These items clustered below −0.6 and were uniformly opposed by participants. By contrast, claims at the positive extreme emphasize pluralism and field-based judgment (e.g., the rejection of scholarly epistemic monopoly, the value of practitioner-led innovation, and scrutiny of the structures that sustain the theory/practice divide). These items clustered above +0.6 and were uniformly supported. Only one item fell into a narrow bridging zone around the origin (≈0.12), asserting that theorists gain credibility when their work demonstrably improves practice; it split the sample evenly. In short, the scale cleanly separates a "theory-authority" pole from a "practice-pluralist" pole, with a thin connective tissue in between.

This polarization in claim scores was mirrored in the stance data, projected via t-SNE which showed clear clustering: theoreticians to the right, practitioners to the left, and hybrids in between (Figure 2b). Support rates were almost perfectly monotonic with the scaled position of claims: as scores increase, support rises and opposition falls. Items at the positive pole drew unanimous support and no opposition; items at the negative pole drew unanimous opposition and no support. 'No clear evidence' responses were rare overall, but where they occurred, they clustered on intermediate claims rather than at the extremes, suggesting that ambivalence is not about indecision regarding the poles so much as uncertainty about how, and where, to connect them. Together, the ANCO-HITS and stance results demonstrate that despite the collaborative tone of interviews, systematic linguistic polarization emerges, with boundaries between theoreticians, practitioners, and hybrids evident even where individual responses appear moderate.



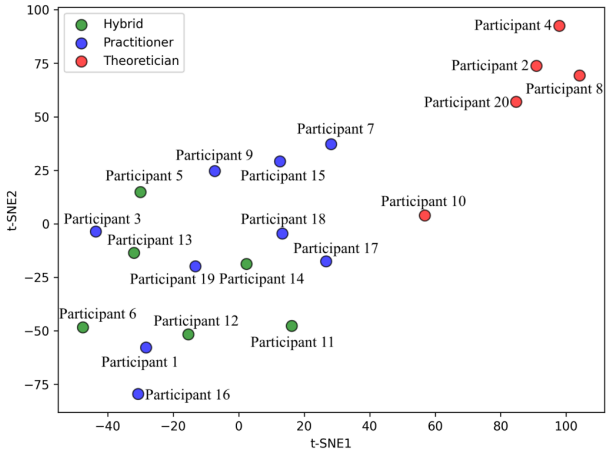


Figure 2(a): Scaled Bipartite Graph

Figure 2(b): t-SNE Visualization of the Participants (in 2D)

Participant roles on the scale

Figure 2(a) shows that the 20 participants spanned a narrower range (0.06 to 1) than the 64 claims (−1 to 1), yet still formed clear, interpretable clusters. Practitioners and hybrids concentrated tightly on the positive side of the scale (means ≈0.92–0.95, with low dispersion), indicating strong alignment with practice-pluralist claims and consistent opposition to theory-authority propositions. Theoreticians also sat on the positive side on average, but were markedly closer to the center (mean ≈0.51) and far more dispersed. Three theoreticians clustered into a small, moderate camp (scores ≈0.07–0.50), while the remaining theoreticians aligned with practitioners and hybrids in the high-positive camp.

These positional differences were reflected in stance behavior. Stance patterns closely tracked claim position for practice-oriented groups but were more qualified among theoreticians. Practitioners and hybrids showed the highest support rates (0.561 and 0.565) and lowest "no clear evidence" shares (0.028 and 0.021), with strong stance–position coupling ($r = 0.879$ and 0.904; slopes = 1.017 and 1.049; all $p < 10^{-19}$). Logistic models confirmed steeper gains in support for these groups, reaching near certainty at the positive pole (≈ 0.99/0.98) versus a lower ceiling for theoreticians (≈ 0.79). Theoreticians, by contrast, exhibited greater ambiguity—the highest "no clear evidence" rate (0.063) and weaker coupling ($r = 0.479$; slope = 0.549; $p < 10^{-19}$)—with sustained uncertainty even for positive claims (≈ 0.35 vs ≈ 0.21 for practitioners). Given that claims were polarized toward the positive pole (median = 0.46; only one centrist claim), practitioners and hybrids formed a cohesive positive camp, while theoreticians—more diffusely distributed (mean = 0.51, SD = 0.30)—served as conceptual bridges: their moderate positioning and attenuated coupling strength (about half that of practice-oriented peers) signaled a pattern of qualified alignment, maintaining interpretive continuity and openness across polarized camps.

Discussion

Across the four analytic dimensions identified in the qualitative analysis, a consistent exploratory pattern emerged: the divide between theoreticians and practitioners was not primarily rooted in incompatible values but in structural conditions that shape how knowledge is produced, communicated, and rewarded. Participants across camps frequently expressed similar commitments to social impact and collaborative problem solving, yet described institutional incentives, temporal misalignments, and communication barriers that keep the two domains apart. Hybrids were particularly instructive in this regard. Rather than representing a distinct epistemic position, hybrids appeared to function as translators who navigate institutional boundaries and reconcile different tempos, expectations, and forms of knowledge. Taken together, these findings suggest that the theory–practice divide persists less because of intellectual disagreement than because of structural inertia in the systems that organize knowledge production and application.

This study examined these dynamics through interviews with twenty theoreticians, practitioners, and hybrids working across social science and social change contexts. Using a mixed-methods design that combined human-led qualitative analysis with AI-assisted quantitative analysis of linguistic stance patterns, we triangulated interpretive insights with computational scaling of participant positions. While recent work has shown that generative AI can support qualitative analysis in large datasets (Karjus, 2025; Lee et al., 2025), here we apply these techniques to a smaller expert dataset to explore whether structural patterns in how participants describe the theory–practice divide can be detected alongside qualitative interpretation.

Our findings suggest a patterned differentiation between theoreticians, practitioners, and hybrids both quantitatively and qualitatively. Nonetheless, there was a majority pull toward engaging with one another that appeared to be largely prevented by institutional and other structural barriers. The results made clear that participants had strong ideas of what constitutes a practitioner, theoretician or in some cases a hybrid: what their values and epistemic orientations are (Theme 1), their sources of disconnection from one another (Theme 2), the dual nature of mutualities and alienation in collaboration (Theme 3); and from this the posited pathways for integration via shared knowledge creation and the fostering of spaces for dialogue and engagement (Theme 4). The findings aligned strongly with Artega et al.'s (2024) cross-disciplinary systematic review, which pointed to systemic gaps and reinforced siloing. Structural tools that serve to improve cyclic integration into one another's systems of knowing, e.g., feeding into both design and interpretation through training and discussion sessions, can soften the 'great divide'.

Qualitative human-led findings framed the existence of polarity in terms of lived experience and epistemic orientation. Returning to the classical framing of this article, epistemic orientations – knowing by *doing* (practitioners) or by *thinking* (theoreticians) came through strongly and contributed to the different aims and approaches held by the two camps (Bartlett & Collins, 2011). Nonetheless, core values were largely similar and positive. Beyond epistemic differences, there were structural sources of disconnect, perhaps most notably divergent timelines with theoreticians working at much slower tempos to practitioners whose pace keeps up with daily changes in the field. This major structural barrier was made only more rigid by challenges with academic gatekeeping, inaccessible academic journal articles, and limited sometimes jargon-filled communication from academics. All participants reported on personal experiences working with those from the other camp and some, the hybrids, crossed these barriers so regularly they were able to speak to both camps. Beneficial experiences revolved around shared knowledge and insights, while alienating experiences were mentioned in a relatively high proportion of practitioner interviews as a pitfall of collaboration.

Together, the ANCO-HITS and stance results generated through AI analyses showed that despite the collaborative tone of interviews, systematic linguistic polarization was pervasive, with boundaries between theoreticians, practitioners and hybrids evident even where individual responses appeared moderate. Statistical joint clustering of claims and participants revealed two clear camps. On one side was a broad practice-pluralist camp comprising nearly all practitioners and hybrids, along with a subset of theoreticians, cohering around claims that valorized situated knowledge, field-driven iteration, and the dismantling of institutional barriers to collaboration. On the other side was an asymmetric participant camp—without clear 'extremes', but defined by a cluster of theory-authority claims that were consistently rejected across the sample, thereby marking the boundary conditions of

acceptable positions. This asymmetry suggests that while participants diverge in emphasis within the practice-pluralist space, the community as a whole converges in rejecting the strongest forms of theory-first gatekeeping.

This leads us to suggest that polarization is issue-centric, not person-centric: the data contained clearly polar claims, but participants, even those most disposed to theory, cluster away from the negative extreme. In other words, polarisation appeared around specific claims rather than fixed participant identities: participants' positions shifted depending on the issue rather than aligning consistently with a single camp. This finding supports previous literature that finds a strong desire to support collective empowerment among academics working on community health projects (Oetzel et al., 2022). Second, cohesion is anchored not by bland consensual statements but by a positive-pole vocabulary that many participants actively endorse, including collaboration, situated expertise, and structural critique of academic gatekeeping. Where disagreement remained, it took the form of calibration: theoreticians in the moderate camp supplied friction against overgeneralization, while practitioners and hybrids pressed to keep collaboration tied to tangible outcomes. The few mid-scale claims that divided the sample evenly were those that conditioned the value of theory on demonstrable improvements in practice.

The qualitative and quantitative findings triangulated, with both indicating that participants themselves tend to cluster toward the practice-pluralist side with little opposition towards barrier-crossing engagement. This alignment suggests that the divide is not sustained by outright opposition but by structural inertia in regard to rigid institutional practices and the absence of deliberate bridging practices (Carton & Ungureanu, 2017). Opportunities therefore lie less in cultivating consensus (Miłkowski, 2024) than in institutionalizing conditions that enable collaborations and outcome-oriented engagements to flourish.

Importantly, hybrids illustrate that sustained crossing between camps is possible, although not without frustration at institutional barriers and communication breakdowns. We do not argue for more hybrids *per se*, but for structural improvements to facilitate dialogue between the camps, including a greater emphasis on outputs beyond peer review journal articles, less jargon in these articles, and time and space dedicated to engaging the two camps with training and discussion. These participant-led suggestions mirror earlier barriers identified in association with the valuable role of scholar-practitioner leadership (i.e., hybrids) in education (Bailey, 2014; Bailey & Gautam, 2015).

When discussing possibilities for integration more broadly, participants had many ideas. These suggestions hinged on a commitment to shared knowledge creation and to fostering dialogue or engagement, for example though shared training, events, and involving one another at the early stages of a project. Participants' calls for "shared knowledge creation" align with broader models of

community-engaged and co-produced research, in which practitioners and scholars jointly shape research questions, interpretation, and implementation rather than occupying strictly separate roles (Wallerstein et al., 2020; Oetzel et al., 2022).

It was also clear that structural changes are required for success. In particular, practical wisdom as a 'master virtue' has become increasingly challenging to either nurture in others or display in one's own actions due to institutional and societal pressures and metrics that emphasise theoretical ways of knowing (Schwartz & Sharpe, 2006). Addressing this challenge may require dedicated time to work together, along with stronger incentives for academics to publish beyond (often paywalled) journals, and communicate with sectors that can use and apply their research. In the UK, this broader effort is termed Knowledge Exchange and is an increasingly important aspect of how universities are monitored and ranked, e.g., by the nationwide compulsory REF, which has run for over a decade (Research Excellence Framework) (Khazragui & Hudson, 2015).

At the same time, our findings suggest that the persistence of the theory–practice divide may not be entirely dysfunctional. Differentiation between theoretical and practical orientations can serve important epistemic and institutional functions. Theoretical work often requires distance from immediate pressures in order to develop abstraction, conceptual clarity, and generalizable insight, while practice-oriented work prioritizes responsiveness, contextual judgment, and action under uncertainty. Maintaining some separation between these domains may therefore allow each to cultivate forms of expertise that would be difficult to sustain under fully integrated conditions. In this sense, the divide between theory and practice may reflect a division of epistemic labour, in which distinct communities specialise in different but complementary ways of knowing (Miłkowski, 2024; Schwartz & Sharpe, 2006). The challenge, then, may be less about eliminating the divide entirely than about creating institutional conditions that allow productive exchange across it.

Limitations and future directions

Our design suffered from several limitations. First, we do not know of a comparable REF system that prizes knowledge exchange in the US and, as such, participant responses may differ by both nation and age in relation to the prevalence of structural support. Additionally, our recruitment strategy involved personal invitations and snowball sampling to gain interviewees who would have the expertise to comment on theory and practice sufficiently, i.e., to be leaders in their field. The authors reflected on their selection to try and reduce the risks of cherry-picking and maintained open research questions. To further mitigate against this, we ensured a balance of experience, gender, ethnic background, and European or North American residence. Due to our small sample size and focus on individuals working on social matters for within-group consistency, there are issues with

generalizability and we encourage further research with more diverse samples working on more varied topics before applying the results more broadly.

The quantitative approach also has several limitations. First, LLM-based claim generation and stance detection risk hallucinations; this was mitigated by requiring evidence-based outputs for transparency. Second, while ANCO-HITS effectively distinguished collaboration-oriented and theory-first camps—with hybrids clustering alongside practitioners—applications with more than two labels may require multi-partite graphs or enhanced variants. Third, while the twenty participants provided sufficient coverage, the interview design—framed around collaboration rather than controversy—skewed the distribution of positions, yielding broad claim coverage (−1 to +1) but uneven participant dispersion.

More broadly, there are analytical challenges to reliance on interview data and participants' self-reported experiences. This study adopts the common qualitative research approach of taking participants' accounts as meaningful representations of how they understand and navigate their professional worlds (Braun & Clarke, 2006). Nonetheless, self-reported attitudes and experiences do not necessarily map directly onto observable behaviours or organisational outcomes. Participants may present their roles, motivations, or collaborations in ways that reflect retrospective interpretation, professional norms, or aspirational identities. As such, the findings should be understood as capturing how actors perceive and narrate the theory–practice relationship rather than as direct measures of how interactions between theoreticians and practitioners unfold in practice. Future research could complement interview-based approaches with observational or organisational data to examine how these dynamics play out in real-world settings.

Future research could build on the present findings by examining how the orientations described here translate into observable professional practices and institutional outcomes. While this study focuses on participants' accounts of their experiences and perspectives, complementary approaches could investigate how theoreticians, practitioners, and hybrids engage in knowledge production, collaboration, and implementation within organisational settings. Such work might combine interview-based insights with institutional data, observational methods, or collaborative project analyses to better understand how these roles operate in practice. Developing this line of inquiry would also align with broader institutional efforts to strengthen knowledge exchange and impact, providing a clearer picture of how different actors contribute to the creation, translation, and application of knowledge.

A further limitation across this approach concerns the categorisation of participants as theoreticians, practitioners, or hybrids. While these categories were useful for structuring the analysis, in practice the boundaries between them may be more fluid than this classification implies. Many participants

described careers and identities that moved across research and practice over time, suggesting that these roles may be better understood as existing along a spectrum rather than as discrete groups. The categorisation used here should therefore be interpreted as an analytical device rather than a definitive typology. Future research could examine these positions using continuous or network-based approaches to better capture the fluid movement between theoretical and practical domains.

Conclusions

Our results indicate strong opinions and feelings from theoreticians, practitioners, and hybrids. When matters concerning ways of knowing and how to engage with research arose, there was an overwhelming dissatisfaction with communication between theory and practice. We found a nagging sense of unrealized potential in the interaction between theoreticians and practitioners. Our interviews suggest a kind of polite mutual marginality, entailing limited attention to, and engagement with, one another's' work. The result is that potential for collaboration between theory and practice is diminished, and a potentially transformative synergy that could benefit society and the academy flickers but has not yet ignited. It is not that the possibility of collaboration does not matter or appeal to theoreticians and practitioners, but rather that thus far it has rarely mattered or appealed *enough* in the complex interplay of differing and overlapping personal and institutional priorities to move them to initiate and regularize collaboration. From an Aristotelian perspective, these findings indicate that *theoria* (knowledge-oriented inquiry) and *phronesis* (practical reasoning oriented toward action) represent distinct but interdependent orientations, whose relationship is shaped by the institutional and structural conditions in which they operate. Understanding different ways of knowing helps shape what kinds of questions get asked, which people are valued as knowledge producers, how evidence is used (or ignored), and ultimately the social impact of research.

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